

The automation wave is not *gender-neutral*.

Women's jobs are disproportionately on the front line — and most women don't have access to the reskilling that would change that.

6

MUST-KNOW SIGNALS

2–10 MAR

COVERAGE WINDOW

4

EMERGING SIGNALS

W11 2026

CALENDAR WEEK

TL;DR — SIGNAL TO ACTION

- International Labour Organization (ILO) confirms women face nearly 2× the workplace AI automation risk — audit your team's roles for gendered automation exposure now.
- Generation Z women unemployment surging (UK: 9.5% → 11.8%) — invest in vocational AI skills pathways for young women.
- 46% of women fear professional backlash from using AI at work — create psychological safety and universal AI access policies.
- Deepfake abuse up 900%; women are 93% of targets — tighten privacy settings and demand platform accountability.
- EU Pay Transparency deadline under pressure — start pay audits now; assume enforcement will tighten globally.

MUST KNOW

01

ILO: Women Face Nearly 2× the Workplace Risk from Generative AI

GLOBAL · LABOR MARKET

A landmark ILO research brief (5 March 2026) finds that 29% of female-dominated occupations are exposed to generative AI, compared to 16% of male-dominated ones. In the highest-exposure category, the ratio is starker still: 16% vs. 3%. Women are concentrated in clerical, administrative, and business support roles where tasks are routine and codifiable. In 88% of countries analysed, women are more exposed than men. In the UK, Switzerland, and the Philippines, over 40% of women's employment is in exposed roles.

Why it matters: The automation wave is not gender-neutral — women's jobs are disproportionately on the front line, and most lack access to AI reskilling.

WORK

RISK

02

Gen Z Women Become the 'New Face of Unemployment' as AI Reshapes Entry-Level Jobs

UK / GLOBAL · LABOR MARKET

PwC's Women in Work 2026 report shows UK female unemployment jumped from 3.5% to 4.2% in one year, driven by young women aged 16–24 where rates rose from 9.5% to 11.8%. Women with low educational attainment and health conditions are 4× more likely to be classified as not in education, employment, or training (NEET). Traditional female-dominated entry points — retail, care, hospitality — are shrinking while male-dominated trades remain robust.

Why it matters: Without targeted AI vocational training for young women, a generation risks being locked out of the workforce entirely.

WORK

03

Nearly Half of Women Fear Professional Backlash from Using AI at Work

CANADA · CULTURAL

A survey of 1,502 Canadians by Monday Girl (released 10 March 2026) finds 46% of women worry about negative consequences from using AI at work, vs. 40% of men. Only 36% of women feel confident with AI tools (men: 52%). 47% of women feel intimidated by AI (men: 33%). Generation Z women show even higher anxiety at 53%. The confidence gap is not about capability — it is about access, training, and psychological safety.

Why it matters: If women self-censor on AI adoption, the productivity and promotion gap will compound rapidly.

CULTURAL

WORK

04

Women Disappearing from Europe's Tech Workforce — Down to 19%

EUROPE · LABOR MARKET

McKinsey's analysis of 4 million LinkedIn profiles finds women hold just 19% of core tech roles in Europe, down 3 percentage points from the prior year. Only 8% of executive tech roles are held by women. 82% of women in tech report having to prove themselves more than male colleagues. Women take on approximately 200 hours per year of unpaid administrative work ("office housework"). AI-related roles are seeing men capture a larger share of entry-level positions.

Why it matters: As AI restructures the tech workforce, the shrinking pipeline means fewer women will shape how AI is built and governed.

WORK

MARKET

05

Deepfake Abuse Surges 900% — Women Are 93% of Targets

GLOBAL / INDIA · GENDERED RISKS

A report by pi-labs (released 10 March 2026) documents a roughly 900% increase in deepfake content, with 93% of explicit deepfakes targeting women. In India, cybercrime complaints involving women rose approximately 60% in two years (50,000 to 80,000 cases). Globally, 62% of deepfake abuse cases against women go unreported due to stigma. Over 5,000 face-swap applications and 1,000 voice-cloning tools are freely available online. Note: the 900% figure lacks a disclosed baseline year — treat as directional evidence of rapid growth, not a precise measurement.

Why it matters: Freely available AI tools are enabling harassment at industrial scale, and most victims have no recourse.

RISK

GENDER

06

EU Pay Transparency Directive: BusinessEurope Asks for 2-Year Pause

EUROPEAN UNION · POLICY

With less than 3 months until the 7 June 2026 transposition deadline, BusinessEurope has formally requested the European Commission to pause the Pay Transparency Directive for two years, citing "unworkable administrative complexity." Denmark has confirmed it will miss the deadline. Ireland says employers will not be penalised for delays. Legal analysts say a formal pause is "extremely unlikely" — expect staggered, imperfect implementation instead.

Why it matters: Pay transparency is coming regardless of delays — companies that start audits now will have a compliance advantage.

Whether the European Commission rejects the pause request formally before the June deadline, which would accelerate compliance pressure on unprepared companies.

01 AI skills gender gap is self-reinforcing

Randstad data shows 71% of men vs. 29% of women have AI skills. Only 27% of US women (vs. 34% of men) have been offered AI upskilling. Training budgets flow to already-male tech teams, creating a compounding loop.

02 Grok deepfake scandal shapes global policy

London School of Economics (LSE) analysis (6 March) frames the crisis as systemic misogyny enabled by technology. Regulatory responses now span UK (Ofcom investigation), EU (4 countries), and Southeast Asia. In-app purchases rose 18% when nudification was a paid feature.

03 AI-driven layoffs may reverse — the 'Boomerang Effect'

Gartner predicts half of companies that cut staff for AI will rehire by 2027. Only 20% of leaders who cut headcount actually did so because of AI. Klarna's AI customer service experiment failed; company is rehiring humans.

04 Council of Europe issues AI + gender equality recommendation

New guidance identifies AI's acute impact on gender equality across policy fields, urging member states to integrate gender perspectives into AI governance frameworks.

OPPORTUNITIES

- + AI reskilling as new on-ramp: McKinsey identifies targeted reskilling to move mid-career women into AI-adjacent roles as Europe's most tangible lever.
- + When access barriers are removed, women adopt AI at higher rates proportionally than men — Version 1 data shows women led adoption when universal Copilot access was granted.
- + CSW70 Agreed Conclusions create a normative baseline for digital justice that civil society can use as leverage.

RISKS

- Diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) rollback in US and Europe could undermine the programs needed to close AI gender gaps.
- Deepfake tools proliferating faster than regulation — 5,000+ face-swap apps available, platforms slow to act.
- AI confidence gap compounds into promotion gap: women who self-censor on AI use fall behind in visibility and advancement.
- Entry-level job contraction disproportionately affects women, potentially creating a lost generation of professionals.

ILO — Women and Generative AI GLOBAL

— 'Gen AI, Occupational Segregation and Gender Equality in the World of Work', 5 March 2026 (ilo.org)

PwC Women in Work 2026 UK / GLOBAL

— PwC 'Women in Work 2026' report (pwc.co.uk); NY Post 9 March; Fortune 5 March

AI Confidence Gap CANADA

— Monday Girl / Angus Reid — 'Women and AI in the Workplace Report 2026', 10 March (businesswire.com)

Women in European Tech EUROPE

— McKinsey — 'Women in Tech and AI in Europe', March 2026 (mckinsey.com); Euronews 8 March

Deepfake Abuse GLOBAL / INDIA

— pi-labs deepfake abuse report, 10 March 2026; Economic Times India; MediaNews4U

EU Pay Transparency EU

— Lewis Silkin, 10 March 2026; BusinessEurope letter 27 Feb 2026; Irish Times 10 March

CSW70 GLOBAL

— UN Press Release WOM/2249, 9 March 2026; UN Women CSW70
(unwomen.org)

AI Skills Gap GLOBAL

— Diginomica / Randstad — 'IWD 2026: Why is there still a big AI gender
skills gap?', March 2026

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